

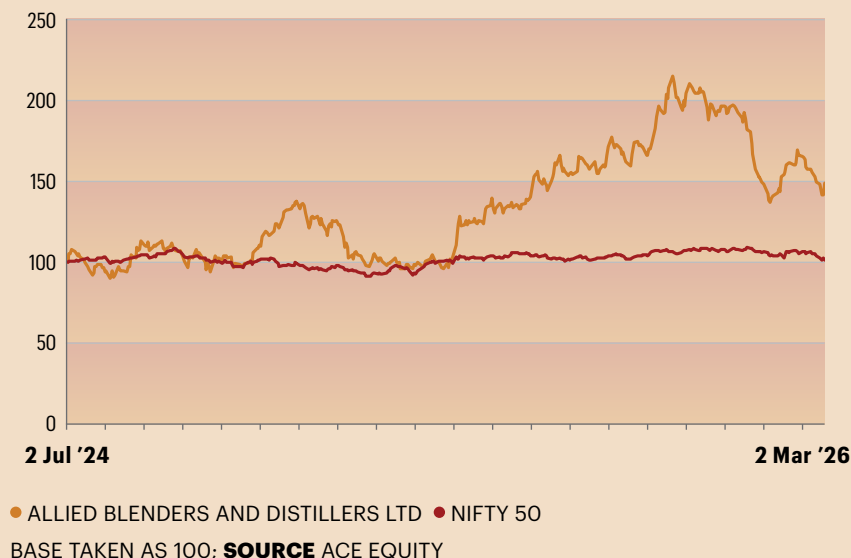


“The landscape for consumer experience has changed very quickly. With ABD Maestro, we have been able to build this skill set and culture, given the premium focus of our portfolio”

BIKRAM BASU
MD, ABD MAESTRO

BEATING THE BENCHMARK

▶ ABD's healthy returns are a result of the company building on its strengths across key markets, thereby providing value to investors



integration strategy. Apart from just good visibility on profitability, the simplicity of that strategy is a huge plus,” says Abhijeet Kundu, Co-Head of Research, Institutional equities, at Antique Stock Broking.

THE PORTFOLIO PIECE

Of ABD's 33 million cases (one case is 9 litres) sold in FY25, Officer's Choice whisky in the mass premium segment (launched in 1988) accounted for 18.3 million cases. However, Iconiq White whisky has been the real success. The idea behind Iconiq is to reduce dependence on Officer's Choice.

Launched in 2022, it sold 5.7 million cases in FY25, and 7.7 million cases in the first nine months of the current fiscal. Speaking of the gap in the market, Gupta points to consumer feedback on why most whisky brands looked the same.

“If you think about it, it's really about black, blue and red, making it somewhat predictable,” he explains. When it came to blends or tastes, it was clear consumers were willing to try something new. “Finally, we went for a white label, kept the language on the bottle

simple and just made it an uncomplicated offering,” says Gupta.

At ABD, each brand is looked at closely, regardless of how old it may be. It perhaps explains why Officer's Choice in the mass premium segment delivers gross margins upwards of 45%. This is at a time when that space is growing the slowest on the back of a more aspirational bunch of consumers moving on to more expensive options.

Kundu says healthy margins are the result of ABD building on its strengths across key markets, ensuring brand recall is very high. “It is a good example of sensible capital allocation.”

SUPER PREMIUM AND BEYOND

Last March, ABD shifted its premium brands portfolio to a new entity called ABD Maestro. The parent put in ₹70 crore for an 80% holding, with the other 20% being picked up by actor Ranveer Singh, who came aboard as co-founder and creative partner.

Bikram Basu, MD of ABD Maestro, says it was possible to sell super-premium and luxury brands